



RIO DE JANEIRO BRAZIL

Feijoada in Rio de Janeiro

There is nothing that the people of Rio de Janeiro enjoy more than the beach. Unless it's a *feijoada*. Brazil's national dish is not so much food as the center of social celebration. After a swim off Ipanema Beach, a walk through Tijuca National Park, or a bit of shopping, families get together on Sunday lunchtimes over this hearty bean-and-meat stew to catch up and chew the fat.



Ipanema is the most famous beach in Brazil. This stunning sweep of pearly sand is sandwiched between towering headlands that twinkle with lights in the lilac dusk. A towering statue of Christ watches over it all, perched high on the rocky, rain forest covered mountain of Corcovado. The Atlantic Ocean is bottle-green and the weather eternally sunny.

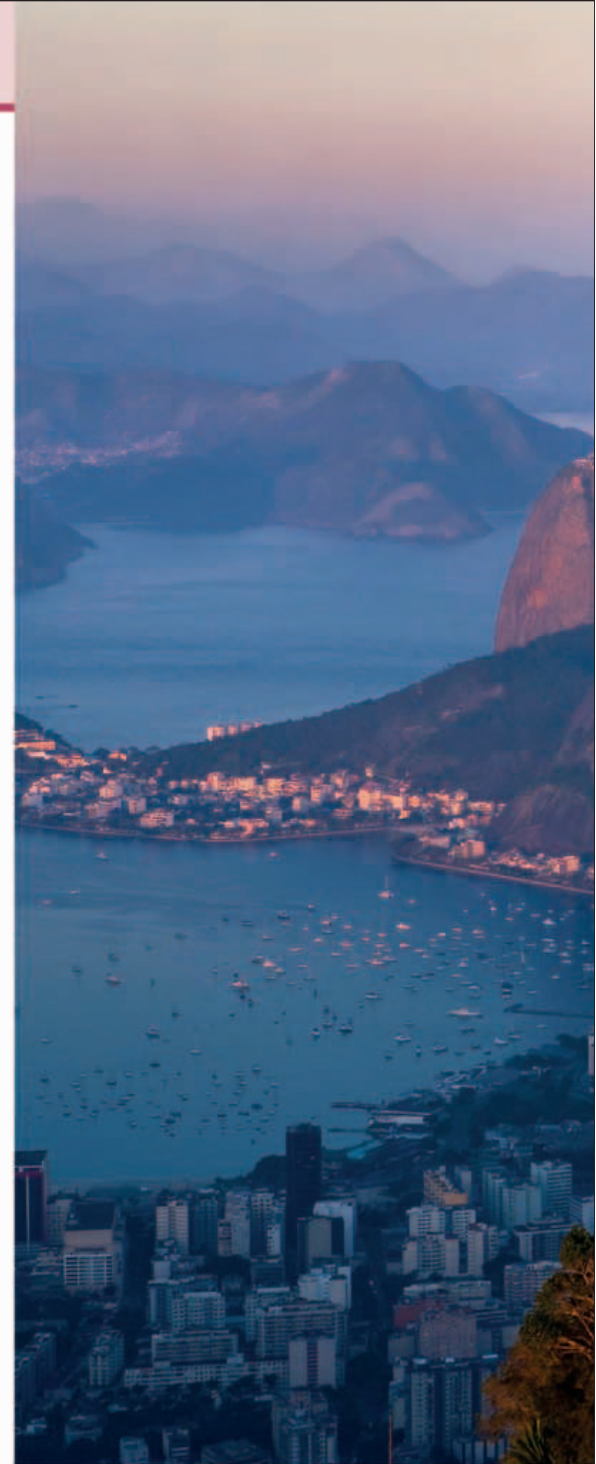
Ipanema is also Rio's most fashionable neighborhood, packed with chic shops, swish restaurants, and cafés, and frequented by Brazil's beautiful people. Not far away, vast slum cities sprawl up the surrounding hillsides. The communities are a world apart, but united by the love of a few key things: samba, soccer, the beach, and the national dish, *feijoada*.

Feijoada is a black bean, pork, and sausage stew that is simmered for hours in a clay pot and served with rice, spring greens, *farofa* (pan-fried manioc flour), slices of orange, and strong *cachaça* rum. The dish is almost as old as Brazil itself: legend has it that *feijoada* evolved from stews cooked by Brazilian and African slaves on the sugar plantations in northeastern

Brazil, from leftovers given to them by the Portuguese and meager amounts of homegrown food. There was little time for preparation, but meat offcuts and beans could be quickly thrown in a pot to simmer over hot embers all day as the slaves worked the fields.

Like samba music, the dish spread from Brazil's poor communities to the rest of the country over the centuries. In the 19th century, a French traveler to Brazil, Augustin Saint-Hilaire, noted that black bean stew was as common at a rich man's table as it was in the wattle-and-daub houses of his slaves, and by 1833 a dish called *feijoada à la Brazilian* (beans Brazilian-style) was being served in high-society restaurants.

By the 20th century, eating *feijoada* every Friday had become a countrywide ritual to mark the end of the work week. Nowadays most Brazilians, rich or poor, get together for a Sunday *feijoada* lunch with family and friends. Visitors can enjoy the dish in a similar way – in good company and over several lunch-time hours – at one of Rio's traditional *feijoada* restaurants. The best (*see facing page*) sits just behind the beach in Ipanema, strategically positioned for diners to work up an appetite with a swim.



Above The statue of *Christ the Redeemer* overlooks Rio from the Corcovado mountain in the Tijuca National Park; it can be reached by cable car

Rio's Restaurant Street

Rua Dias Ferreira, a five-minute taxi ride from Ipanema, is one of South America's top foodie destinations. This 550-yd (500-m) street is lined with restaurants on both sides – from swanky São Paulo fusion establishments to nouvelle cuisine sushi, Brazilian Thai, and, of course, the inevitable spit-roast meat restaurants. This is the place for a leisurely stroll on a balmy evening, when you're in search of a restaurant. The most famous are **Carlota** (www.carlota.com.br), serving Brazilian food with an Asian and French twist; **Zuka** (www.zuka.com.br), with its fabulous beef; **Sushi Leblon** (www.sushileblon.com), where you can try slivers of fish with *pâté de foie gras*; and **Sawasdee** (www.sawasdee.com.br), with a Brazilian take on Southeast Asian cooking that is heavy on flavor and low on spice.

A Day in Rio de Janeiro

With breathtaking views at every turn, mountains covered in rain forest, and a myriad marvelous beaches, Rio de Janeiro is resolutely an outdoor city. *Cariocas*, as the locals are called, meet, greet, and eat outdoors.

MORNING Spend the morning on **Ipanema beach** – leave your valuables in the hotel and take nothing more than a *kanga* (shawl) and a *tanga* (bikini) or *sunga* (swimming briefs) with you to the beach. In the late morning, wander Ipanema's streets in search of a café or juice bar for lunch.

AFTERNOON Take a helicopter flight over the **Christ at Corcovado** for possibly the world's most unforgettable urban views. Land on the summit of the **Morro de Urca** mountain and spend the day walking around the forests here and the neighboring **Sugar Loaf** mountain (reachable by cable car).

EVENING Swing and sway to the samba beat in a bar, club, or just on the streets in **Lapa**, Rio's liveliest nightlife neighborhood, which is packed with party crowds at the weekend. Or opt for a more elegant evening spent sipping a cocktail in the super-chic 1920s **Copacabana Palace** or the Philippe Starck **Fasano** hotel.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Domestic and international airlines fly into Rio's Tom Jobim international **airport**. The city can be reached by **bus** from all over Brazil. The best way to get around Rio is by **subway** or **taxi**.

WHERE TO STAY

Cama e Café (inexpensive) offers bargain homestays and the chance of *feijoada* with a local family. www.camaecafe.com.br

Arpoador Inn (moderate) sits in a modest block in a superb location overlooking the Atlantic. www.arpoadorinn.com.br

Fasano (expensive) is the most luxurious hotel in the city, situated right on the beach in Ipanema. www.fasano.com.br

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.rioguiaooficial.com.br